



The Power of **the** **One Pager**

PITCHBIRD · FOUNDER GUIDE

PITCHBIRD · FOUNDER GUIDE · CHAPTER 7

The Power of the One Pager

Investors decide whether to take your call in less than 15 seconds. The one-pager is the document that has to survive that test.

A pitch deck wins the room. The one-pager wins the chance to be in the room. It travels in inboxes, sits on phone screens, and gets forwarded between partners - usually without you in the conversation.

Drawing on Pitchbird's work with thousands of founders, this guide distils the eight non-negotiables every one-pager needs, the four upgrades that turn competent into memorable, and the design principles that respect how investors actually read.

In the following pages, you'll learn:

- The 8 elements every one-pager must have
- The 4 high-leverage additions to consider
- How investors scan - and what to put where their eyes go
- When the one-pager helps and when it limits you

Magdalena Reith · Founder, Pitchbird

“Well-designed one-pagers turn cold inboxes into conversations that change everything.”



01: Why it matters

One sheet of paper. One decision.

The one-pager is the door, not the room. Done well, it earns you the meeting. Done badly, it earns you silence - and you'll never know which line lost you the deal.

A pitch deck wins the room. The one-pager wins the chance to be in the room. It travels in inboxes, sits on phone screens, and gets forwarded between partners - usually without you in the conversation.

That means every element has to do double duty: **introduce, intrigue, and stand on its own.** VCs process pitch documents as self-contained assets. Partners share them with colleagues who may evaluate them without you present. (PitchGrade / DocSend, 2024)

Funding Blueprint (2026) found that a well-structured one-pager reduces decision friction by approximately **47%** compared to a full pitch deck - while maintaining narrative control. That's the edge in cold outreach.

32%

of decision-makers drop off after 15 seconds of reading a one-pager. The first impression is the only impression.

SOURCE · STORYDOC, 2024



Investors don't read - they scan a Z. The page has to deliver on that path or it doesn't deliver at all.

02: The framework

The eight non-negotiables

If a one-pager misses any of these, it is incomplete. Treat this as the checklist before you send anything.

**01**

Company name & logo

Identity is the anchor. Investors know who they're dealing with before they read a single word.

**02**

Contact information

The most-skipped basic. If they can't reach you in one click, the document did nothing.

**03**

Company profile

A short, informative introduction - what you are, who you serve, why you exist.

**04**

Business idea

Describe the core concept in one tight sentence. No jargon, no hedging.

**05**

Unique selling proposition

What makes this venture distinct from the next ten emails in the inbox.

**06**

Roadmap & timeline

Graphically show where the business is going and when. Visual beats prose here.

**07**

Investment ask

The amount needed, the structure (one-time or tranches), and the deadline. Specific.

**08**

Investment highlights

The three or four reasons this allocation pays back. Punchy, not vague.



03: Beyond the basics

Add these if you have the space

The four below are the most common upgrades. Together, they turn a competent one-pager into a memorable one.

Problem



Frame the pain in market terms before you frame yourself.

Investors connect with the problem first. Make them feel it before you sell the cure.

Solution



Show how your business removes that pain. Two lines, max.

Lead with the outcome - not the mechanism. Save the how for the deck.

Traction



Prove customers want it. Revenue, signups, LOIs - whichever you have.

Proof beats promise. Companies leading with traction close 6.4 weeks faster. (Funding Blueprint, 2026)

Market



Who you sell to, and the competitive landscape they live in.

Investors want a beachhead, not 'everyone'. Show the wedge first.

04: Design principles

How investors actually read it

Content is king

Clarity first. Strong narrative - problem, solution, impact. Hierarchy via headings, sub-heads, and bullets that guide the eye.

Visually appealing

Clean composition, generous white space, strategic visuals over walls of text. Colour evokes brand, not chaos.

Remember your audience

Investors scan, not read. Lead with what helps their decision. Professional, confident tone throughout.

Call to action

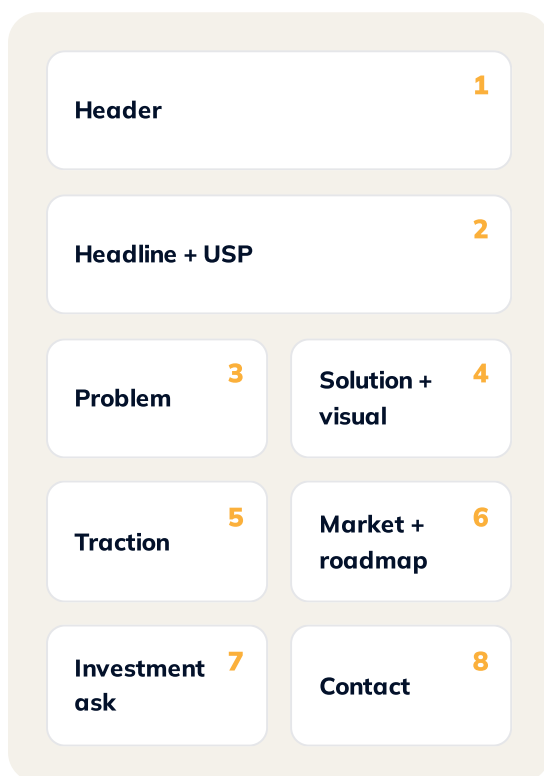
End with one specific ask. 'Schedule a 20-minute call.' Not 'we'd love to chat sometime.'



04: Anatomy

Where everything goes on the page

Investors don't read a one-pager - they scan it in a Z-shape, top-left to bottom-right. The eight elements earn their spot only when they sit where eyes already land.



1 Header

Logo + company name. Often the only thing the partner remembers ten minutes later - make it work.

2 Headline + USP

One sentence that earns the next 14 seconds of attention. Lead with the outcome, not the mechanism.

3 Problem

Pain in the customer's words. Numbers if you have them, story if you don't.

4 Solution + visual

How you remove the pain - paired with a mock-up, screenshot or icon. Visual carries weight here.

5 Traction

Proof. Revenue, signups, LOIs, pilots. One number beats a paragraph of optimism.

6 Market + roadmap

Beachhead first, then the trajectory. 6/12/24-month milestones in a single timeline.

7 Investment ask

The amount, the structure, the deadline. Specific. No 'flexible'.

8 Contact

Name, email, phone, LinkedIn. The most-skipped detail. Don't skip it.

05: Design in practice

What separates a readable one-pager from a rejected one

The difference is rarely the idea - it's the execution of the page itself. Eight calls investors make in the first scan.

DON'T	DO
✗ Dense, unbroken paragraphs that force the investor to find the headline	✓ One dominant headline - 14pt or larger - visible without scrolling or rotating
✗ Revenue model buried below line 8 - 71% of readers never reach it. (River Editor, 2026)	✓ Revenue model in the top-half of the page, on the natural Z-scan path
✗ 900+ words crammed onto a single page	✓ 400-500 words with white space. (Storydoc, 2024)
✗ No funding ask, or vague 'seeking strategic partners' language	✓ Specific ask: amount, instrument (SAFE / equity), and close date
✗ Team section missing - or 'bios available on request'	✓ Founder names, roles, one credibility signal each
✗ Three fonts, five brand colours, a stock-photo background	✓ One primary font, two colours, one well-chosen image
✗ Contact info on a second page, or missing entirely	✓ Email, phone, LinkedIn in the bottom-right - every time
✗ Runs to 1.5 or 2 pages - investor stops at the scroll	✓ Hard stop at one page. If it doesn't fit, cut - don't extend.

The one-pager must be designed for rapid comprehension without verbal explanation. Partners share it with colleagues who may evaluate it without you present. (PitchGrade / DocSend Data, 2024)

06: Examples

What strong one-pagers look like

Three patterns we see in the one-pagers that earn meetings - backed by published investor-engagement data.

THE ORIGINAL LEAN PITCH

Airbnb (2008)

FREE STARTUP FUNDING, 2024

Airbnb began as a simple one-pager built on WordPress before it raised a single dollar. It named the problem (no affordable short-term accommodation), the model (peer-to-peer room rental), and the founders. No deck. No presentation. One page.

The idea earned the meeting. The one-pager was the proof it could be communicated clearly.

STRUCTURE OVER LUCK

Warm-intro advantage

PITCHGRADE / DOCSEND,
2024

DocSend data shows warm introductions convert at **40-50%** versus **3-5%** for cold decks. A well-crafted one-pager sent to a mutual contact converts cold outreach into a warm intro - before the deck ever opens.

Use the one-pager as the ask for an introduction, not as a substitute for one.

06: Examples cont.

And one more pattern

The third - and most consequential - pattern: the order in which information lands.

FASTER CLOSES BY 6.4
WEEKS

Traction-first sequencing

FUNDING BLUEPRINT, 2026

Funding Blueprint's analysis found that companies leading with traction metrics - not vision statements - close funding rounds **6.4 weeks faster**. The first thing the investor reads sets the frame for everything that follows.

Lead with your best proof point. Vision supports traction. Not the other way around.

What all strong one-pagers share: the problem is named in one line, the ask is on the page, the team is visible, and it fits on a single sheet without shrinking the font below 10pt.

07: Word economy

Cut to 500 words. Then cut again.

The 400-500 word limit is the threshold above which investors stop reading. (Storydoc, 2024)

The discipline of cutting is the work - and here is how to do it.



Start with a word count

Paste your draft into any word processor. If it reads over 500 words, you are not done yet. Count before you edit - not after.

- ✗ Our proprietary, AI-powered platform leverages cutting-edge machine learning algorithms to deliver personalised, data-driven insights that help enterprise customers optimise their operational workflows and significantly reduce costs.

- ✓ Our AI platform cuts enterprise operating costs by 30% in under 90 days.



Kill the adjectives first

Ask every adjective and adverb: does this add data, or does it add enthusiasm? Enthusiasm is free; data is not. Every 'innovative', 'revolutionary', 'world-class' costs you credibility, not goodwill.

- ✗ Our highly experienced, passionate team of world-class experts has developed a truly innovative solution.

- ✓ Our team has built and exited two SaaS companies. The solution is in pilot with three enterprise clients.



One sentence per idea

A sentence with three clauses is three sentences that haven't been separated yet. If a sentence runs past 20 words, break it. Read it aloud - if you run out of breath, it's too long.

- ✗ We are targeting the rapidly growing SME market segment in the DACH region, which represents an addressable market of over €4 billion annually and has historically been underserved by existing SaaS providers.

- ✓ Target: SMEs in DACH. Addressable market: €4bn. Underserved by every existing SaaS provider.



Replace paragraphs with bullets

Three consecutive sentences listing related things are a bullet list in disguise. Bullets scan faster, skip slower, and - critically - take up less vertical space on the page.

- ✗ The funding will be used to expand our sales team, accelerate product development, and build out our customer success function to support expected growth.

- ✓ Use of funds: sales (40%) · product (35%) · customer success (25%)



The five-word test

Can you summarise the business in five words? If not, the headline is doing too much. The headline's job is to make the investor read the next line - not explain everything.

- ✗ Building the future of sustainable urban mobility for the next generation of city commuters.

- ✓ EV scooter rentals for cities.



08: First 60 seconds

What they read, in what order.

Investors don't read a one-pager. They scan it - in a Z-shape, top-left to bottom-right - and decide in the first 15 seconds whether to keep going. 32% drop off before that window closes. (Storydoc, 2024) Understanding their path is the single most actionable thing you can do.

0-5 sec

THEY LOOK AT

Header: logo, company name, tagline.

Identity and category signal. The tagline must name the category and the outcome - not a slogan. If the investor can't place the business in five seconds, the rest is irrelevant.

THEIR QUESTION

"Do I recognise this space? Is this category interesting to me?"

5-15 sec

THEY LOOK AT

Headline + USP - the sentence that earns the next 45 seconds.

Lead with the outcome, not the mechanism. 'We help enterprise HR teams cut onboarding by half' beats 'We are an AI-powered HR automation platform.'

THEIR QUESTION

"Is this a big enough problem? Is this approach credible?"



08: First 60 seconds cont.

The decision window

By second 15, the partner has decided whether to keep reading. The next 15 seconds decide whether the proof is real.

15-30 sec

THEY LOOK AT

Traction and team - the proof this is real.

Investors spend an average of 62 seconds on team in pitch decks. (PitchGrade / DocSend, 2024) In a one-pager that scrutiny compresses into a few lines. One credibility signal per founder. One traction proof with a number.

THEIR QUESTION

"Is there evidence this works? Can I trust who is building it?"

The 8-line rule. If your revenue model is not visible in the first eight lines of the document, 71% of readers never see it. (River Editor, 2026) That is not a layout preference - it is a structural requirement. Count the lines in your draft. The problem, the model, and the traction must all land above that threshold.

08: First 60 seconds cont.

The reply window

Past second 30, the partner has decided whether to read the deck. The last 30 seconds decide whether to reply tonight, tomorrow, or never.

30-60 sec

THEY LOOK AT

Investment ask and contact.

Companies leading with traction close 6.4 weeks faster than those leading with vision. (Funding Blueprint, 2026) Make the ask specific: amount, instrument, close date. Then make response trivial - email, phone, LinkedIn, bottom-right.

THEIR QUESTION

"What exactly do they need? How do I respond?"

Make the reply trivial. Email, phone, LinkedIn - bottom-right of the page, every time. A reply that requires looking up a contact is a reply that doesn't happen.

09: Pressure-test

Five tests before you hit send.

You do not need analytics software to know whether a one-pager works. You need five disciplined tests - each surfaces a different failure mode. They take less than a week. They will save you from sending something that quietly fails and never tells you why.



Read it aloud

Print the document or open it on a screen, and read every word out loud at normal speaking pace - without pausing to correct yourself mid-sentence.

- ✓ Read straight through without hesitation. Pace feels like a confident conversation.
- ✗ You stumble, slow down, or have to re-read a sentence. Every stumble is a sentence that is too dense or too long.



Three advisors, separately

Send to three people who understand your space but are not inside your company. Same brief: 'Read this cold. Tell me what's unclear, what's missing.' Never as a group.

- ✓ Each person flags something different - minor, specific, fixable.
- ✗ Two or more flag the same thing. That is not preference. It's a broken element. Fix it.



The 5-second test, with 5 founders

Send to five founders - peers who do not know your pitch. Ask: 'After five seconds, what does this company do?' Collect their exact words.

- ✓ Four of five describe the business accurately in one sentence.
- ✗ Fewer than three get it right, or descriptions vary wildly. The headline isn't doing its job.



Print it

Print the one-pager at 100% scale on A4 or letter. Look at it from arm's length before reading a word.

- ✓ Hierarchy is visible. Headline stands out. Clear white space. Looks like a professional document.
- ✗ Looks grey, dense, or cramped. Font below 10pt. No clear visual anchor. Fails on paper = fails on screen.



The 8-must-haves checklist

Open page 03 of this guide. Walk through all eight must-haves - name, contact, profile, business idea, USP, roadmap, ask, highlights.

- ✓ All eight are present. Each is visible without hunting for it.
- ✗ One or more missing, vague, or buried. An incomplete one-pager is a disqualifier - not a work in progress.



10: Failure modes

Why investors stop reading - and where

Each failure below maps to a specific drop-off point in investor attention. Know them before you send.

Runs to more than one page

The investor stops at the scroll. Immediate disqualifier.

STORYDOC, 2024

FIX

Hard-cut at one page. If it doesn't fit, the message isn't tight enough yet.

Revenue model buried below line 8

71% of readers never reach it. They assume you're pre-revenue or hiding something.

RIVER EDITOR, 2026

FIX

Place the revenue model in the top half of the page, on the Z-scan path.

No funding ask - or a vague one

'Seeking strategic investment' is not an ask. Missing status is an immediate disqualifier.

STORYDOC, 2024

FIX

State the amount, instrument (SAFE / equity), and close date. Specific numbers signal preparation.

Team section missing or deferred

Investors spend more time on team than any other section - 1 minute 2 seconds on average. No team = no trust.

PITCHGRADE / DOCSSEND, 2024

FIX

Name the founders, their roles, one credibility signal each. It belongs on the page.

Too many words, too little white space

The ideal is 400-500 words. Above that, the document looks unedited and the reader skips to the exit.

STORYDOC, 2024

FIX

Cut to 500 words. Use white space as structure, not decoration.

Contact information missing or buried

Founders spend weeks on design and forget to include a working email address. Without it, the document did nothing.

CHAPTER 7

FIX

Email, phone, LinkedIn. Bottom-right. Every time, without exception.

11: Trade-offs

What it gives you - and what it can't

STRENGTHS

Respects the investor's time - and signals you respect it too.

Forces sharper thinking. If it doesn't fit on a page, the idea isn't focused yet.

Travels well - easy to forward, print, remember.

LIMITATIONS

Brevity is unforgiving. Every missing detail is a potential rejection.

Hard to write alone - outside eyes catch what founder-bias hides.

Not a substitute for the full deck. It is the door, not the room.



The one-pager is brutal in the right way. If your business doesn't fit on the page, the business isn't sharp yet.

**Want a Pitchbird review of
your one-pager?**

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About the Author

Magdalena Reith is the founder of Pitchbird, an agency specialising in pitch deck design and startup consulting. Since founding Pitchbird in 2015, Magdalena has helped **over 10,000 startups** across a variety of industries tell their stories and secure funding.

With a background in global companies spanning business development, investor relations, and design, Magdalena brings a multidisciplinary perspective to her work with founders. Her expertise includes **crafting compelling investor documents, delivering impactful corporate presentations, and providing personalised pitch coaching** to help startups refine their messaging.

In addition to running Pitchbird, **Magdalena is a frequent speaker and pitch coach for startup programs including Burda Bootcamp and Startup SAFARI**. She has hosted Pitch Masterclasses at Startup SAFARI events, helping founders at all levels shine on stage.

When she's not working with startups, you can find Magdalena enjoying the vibrant scene in Munich and connecting with fellow entrepreneurs.

Connect with her on LinkedIn or learn more about Pitchbird's services at pitchbird.de.



[Connect with Magdalena](#)



FIND US

Let's make your one-pager **land.**

Pitchbird helps founders craft pitch documents that earn the meeting. From a single one-pager review to a full investor-document overhaul - we're a message away.

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